

[Subscribe](#)[Search](#)The logo for the Stimson Center, featuring the word "STIMSON" in a bold, sans-serif font, with a stylized circular icon to the right of the "O".[What We Do](#) ▼[Issues](#) ▼[Analysis](#) ▼[Events & Engagem](#)[Our Experts](#) ▼[Donate](#)

COMMENTARY

Top Ten Global Risks for 2025

Persistent conflict in Africa, the Middle East, and Ukraine; rising tensions with Mexico, China, and North Korea; the consequences of climate change and emerging technologies; and a second Trump presidency may pose heightened risks this year

By **Mathew Burrows** and **Robert A. Manning**

January 13, 2025

Grand Strategy

Share:

Subscribe

Search

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

Originally published in [Foreign Policy](#)

Introduction

The Risks

Rogue America

Probability:

A Spate of Wicked Problems in the Middle East

Probability:

Cascading Clashes in Mexico

Probability:

A Bad Deal or Walkaway in Ukraine

Probability:

China Strikes Back

[What We Do](#) ▼[Issues](#) ▼[Analysis](#) ▼[Events & Engagement](#)[Our Experts](#) ▼[Donate](#)

2025 risks deeper strife, conflict, and uncertainty in an unsettled, contested world. Fears of a Rogue America unraveling the very global order the U.S. created after WW2; growing global—and most troubling—developing nation debt, worsening already fragile and failing states; trending toward a climate tipping point; and confrontation with Mexico are among the top things to worry about in 2025. Some risks from this past year have continued with new layers of conflict in the Middle East, a downward spiral in U.S.-China relations, and the dangers of a governance deficit in rapidly advancing Artificial Intelligence capabilities round out the Top Ten Risks.

Introduction

“Trump may be one of those figures in history, [Henry Kissinger observed](#) in 2018, ”who comes along from time to time to mark the end of an era and forces it to give up its pretenses.” This eighth edition of our annual foresight exercise, **Top Ten Global Risks**, is drawn from our forecasting experience at the National Intelligence Council.

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

Rogue America

Probability:



The most immediate peril is disruption and chaos as the new administration seeks to pursue contradictory competing goals (tariffs vs. lower prices and strong dollar; anti-'globalist' 'America First', yet stronger global Primacy, with competing policy entrepreneur factions) at a time when the world is messier, more complex and dangerous than in Trump's first term.

Trump may be the first post-American Exceptionalist President that is not enamored with democratic values. He thrives in a Hobbesian, transactional, all-against-all world. MAGA disdain of 'globalism' portends unilateral economic interventionism to protect the US economy. Yet his fear of war means military interventions will be limited and reactionary, as in his first term.

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

For Trump's new Stimson as a deal maker could have a positive side if he seeks to use the coercive bargaining techniques to persuade China against increased dumping, strike a bargain with Iran that lowers regional tensions, and encourage more alliance burden-sharing. However, from North Korea and China to Afghanistan, Trump's [previous efforts](#) do not inspire confidence this time around.

A Spate of Wicked Problems in the Middle East

Probability:



The [collapse](#) of the Assad regime in Syria wrought is adding layers of risk on top of the Gaza and Lebanon wars and the Palestinian dilemma. These include the possibility of a new phase of civil conflict in Syria, as external powers like Turkey, Israel, the US, Russia, and internal parties compete to shape a post-Assad Syria; escalating Israel-Iran conflict, and prospective civil strife in a weakened Iran facing succession of 85-year-old Supreme Leader Ayatollah Khamenei.

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

Cascading Clashes in Mexico

Probability:



[Trump's team](#) has reportedly been debating whether to invade and clear out the drug lords. Trump abruptly threatened 25 percent tariffs to stop the flow of drugs, particularly fentanyl, and seal the southern border. Mexico's largest-ever fentanyl bust in December may be a welcome response. Mexican President Sheinbaum has vowed to retaliate any against tariffs which [Deutsche Bank](#) estimates would raise core US inflation by over one percentage point—and disrupt a deeply [integrated](#) North American car market.

Trump needs Mexico's help if he wants to deport 11 million illegal migrants or, as a practical matter, even 1 million. Mexico reportedly has a [plan for receiving deported Mexicans](#), but Sheinbaum wants to convince Trump to keep many of them. While it has been [stopping Central American caravans from reaching the border](#), Mexico temporarily [shut down](#) deportations in 2024. A review of the USMCA signed in Trump's first term is

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate



Trump is intent on ending the Ukraine war and blaming Biden for allowing it to happen. The new President wants to decrease European dependence on the US for its security and stopping the Ukraine war would be a first step. There is growing Republican opposition against any more assistance for Ukraine, which is helping to bring Zelenskyy to the table. With Ukrainian losses increasing, [Kyiv](#) appears—without openly admitting it—desperate for a ceasefire, but Trump may allow Putin to tip the scales.

Trump will face domestic and allied opposition if he presses Ukraine too hard for territorial concessions while squashing Zelensky's demand for NATO membership, offering instead bilateral security guarantees. Putin will want assurances against substantial NATO defense assistance for a neutral Ukraine. [Putin](#) reportedly is making any ceasefire conditional on wider talks on European security arrangements and may want some sanctions eased and restored access to Western financial markets to improve Russia's [gloomy economic](#) outlook.

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagement

Our Experts ▼

Donate



Tension looms between China Hawks and business-centered advisors in the cabinet appealing to Trump’s penchant for deal-making. There was continuity from Trump to Biden in defining China as a [strategic competitor](#) seeking to displace US influence.

But as his [policy architects](#) argued, Biden sought to create a framework to manage competitive coexistence—a “steady state”—balancing and constraining Beijing, while creating [guardrails](#) to avoid conflict. Thus, [Biden maintained](#) and expanded tariffs, tightened tech and investment restrictions, imposed sanctions, and strengthened US deterrence in the Asia-Pacific, but also bolstered risk-reduction mechanisms such as military to military talks.

Trump and many of his [advisors](#), plus Congressional Republicans, [criticize Biden](#) for trying to manage competition; they view the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) as an [existential threat](#) and define an endgame not of coexistence, but ‘victory,’ where the CCP,

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagement

Our Experts ▼

Donate

Moreover, Trump may impose additional tariffs on nations like Mexico, Vietnam, and India – whose US exports have skyrocketed as US investors have [moved production](#) there using Chinese components. The projected [setback](#) to both economies from an all-out economic war might, after much Sturm und Drang, yield a deal.

North Korean Aggression

Probability:



It was a portent of the coming world war when, in 1935, Mussolini and Hitler sent military aid and troops to aid fascists in the Spanish Civil War. Kim Jong Un sent [10,000](#) troops to Ukraine was a worrying echo of the Fascist move.

The burgeoning Eurasian entente is one of several [strategic shifts](#) unfolding since the failed Trump-Kim 2019 [Hanoi Summit](#) that has resulted in a predicament more dangerous than at any time since 1950. Kim has undermined core assumptions of US and South

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

probable agenda.

If Ukraine escalates or if China attacks Taiwan and US troops intervene in either conflict, as [wargames suggest](#), Kim may see the diversion of US focus and resources as an opportunity to attack South Korea, risking a two-front war with nuclear powers. The immediate risk is of escalatory North-South military confrontation, over their [disputed maritime border](#).

Climate Tipping Point

Probability:



The world is approaching a climate [tipping point](#), where change may become irreversible. Limiting temperature increases to 1.5C above pre-industrial levels and “well below 2C“ is the goal of the [Paris Accord](#). Yet, 2024 was the hottest year on record, with temperatures rising over [1.5C degrees](#), after [a decade](#) of the warmest weather on record, and more frequent and extreme weather.

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

This helps explain why, [shortly after the UN climate meeting, the major G20](#) to agree on a timeline to phase out fossil fuels [failed](#). Six nations (China, US, EU, India, Russia, and Brazil) account for nearly [two-thirds of GHG emissions](#) – and deciding how to divide current and historical responsibilities is a thorny diplomatic problem.

Trends suggest deepening risk: Trump will promote fossil fuels and [rollback](#) US climate commitments, and new energy demands from [AI data centers](#) and [cryptocurrencies](#) increase the damage.

A Lost Decade for the World's Poorest

Probability:



Around [3.3 billion people](#) live in nations that spend more on debt than on health and education. Growing deficits and debt are a [global problem](#). The [IMF's Fiscal Monitor](#) has warned that global public debt will likely exceed \$100 trillion, or about 93 percent of

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

As the LDC outlook worsens, the number of active state-based armed conflicts has reached the highest level ever recorded by the [Uppsala Conflict Data Program](#) with gang violence also at a historically high. Rich countries delude themselves in thinking the conflicts won't spill over and affect their futures.

Are Pakistan and Nigeria Too Big to Fail?

Probability:



Pivotal middle powers, such as Nigeria and Pakistan are suffering the plight of the poorer developing states. If stabilized, they could be critical anchors, if they fail, they will be hubs of instability.

Former Nigerian President [Obasanjo](#) labeled his country a “failing state” recently, citing leadership failure and such underlying problems as youth restiveness, discord and

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

There have been recent attacks earlier this year in the Tajikistan-Baluchistan area.

AI/Tech Governance Deficit

Probability:



The fear of AI dominating humans rather than vice-versa, is growing. [Large Language models](#) of generative AI are [rapidly improving](#) their capacity, and some predict breakthroughs in super-intelligence, Artificial General Intelligence (AGI), [by 2030](#). A Musk-backed push on [frontier AGI](#) could be dangerous.

Yet financial analysts worry that the \$1 trillion in [AI investment](#) is lacking in commercial applications. How will Trump's best buddy, Elon Musk, whose PAC gave [\\$200 million](#) to Trump and the [tech lobby](#), impact still uncertain norms and regulations for AI and other emerging tech? There are neither national nor global standards for AI, though there are [over 120 bills](#) pending in Congress and [45 states](#) have pending AI legislation.

[Subscribe](#)

[Search](#)

STIMSON

[What We Do](#) ▼

[Issues](#) ▼

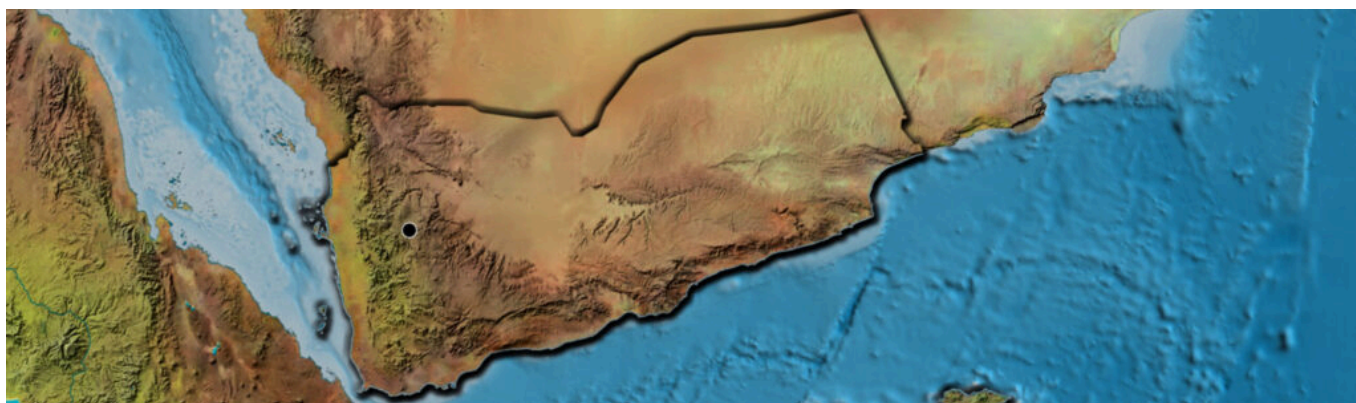
[Analysis](#) ▼

[Events & Engagem](#)

[Our Experts](#) ▼

[Donate](#)

Recent & Related



MIDDLE EAST

Beyond Hormuz: The Sanaa Airport Strike and the Architecture of Iranian Proxy Power

Fatima Abo Alasrar

Subscribe

Search

STIMSON

What We Do ▾

Issues ▾

Analysis ▾

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▾

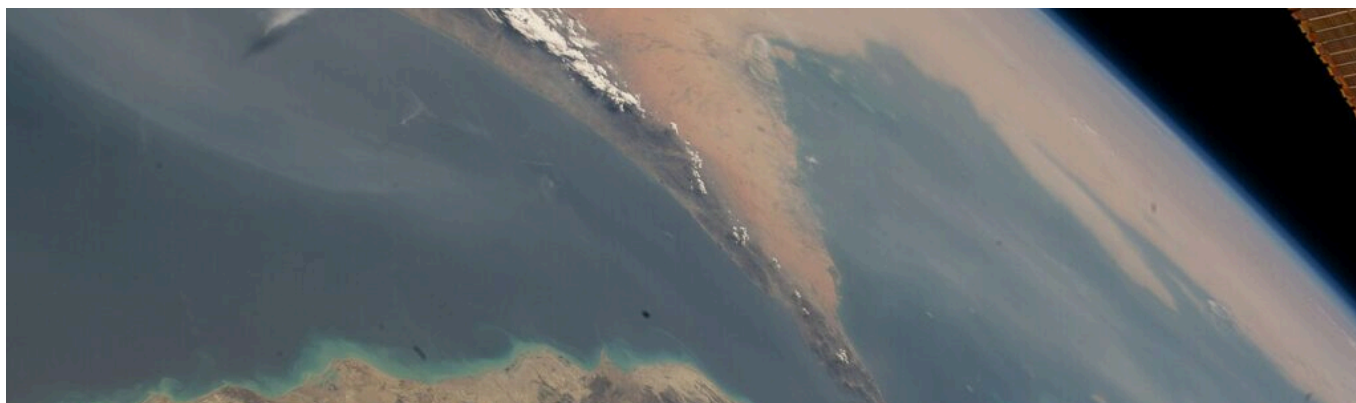
Donate



STRATEGIC FORESIGHT HUB

NATO Summit Assessment: Partial Reversion to the Mean

James Siebens | Andrew Hyde



Subscribe

Search

STIMSON

What We Do ▼

Issues ▼

Analysis ▼

Events & Engagem

Our Experts ▼

Donate

Saeng Moungee

NORTH AFRICA, MEDITERRANEAN, AND THE SAHEL

Tripoli's New Leverage: How the American Initiative Changed the Rules of Negotiation

Hafed Al Ghowell

EAST ASIA

America's Chip Future Still Runs Through Taiwan

Michael Cunningham

MIDDLE EAST

Postwar, Iran Is at a Crossroads

[Subscribe](#)[Search](#)The logo for the Stimson Center, featuring the word "STIMSON" in a bold, sans-serif font, with a stylized circular emblem to the right of the text.[What We Do](#) ▼[Issues](#) ▼[Analysis](#) ▼[Events & Engagem](#)[Our Experts](#) ▼[Donate](#)[David Kenneth Smith](#)

Find an Expert

Home to more than 100 scholars and global affiliates, the Stimson Center is proud to be a magnet for the world's leading experts on the most pressing foreign policy and national security issues of our time. Explore our experts and their work.

[FIND AN EXPERT](#)

Areas of Expertise:

[Strategic Foresight Hub](#) >

[Subscribe](#)

[Search](#)

STIMSON

[What We Do](#) ▼

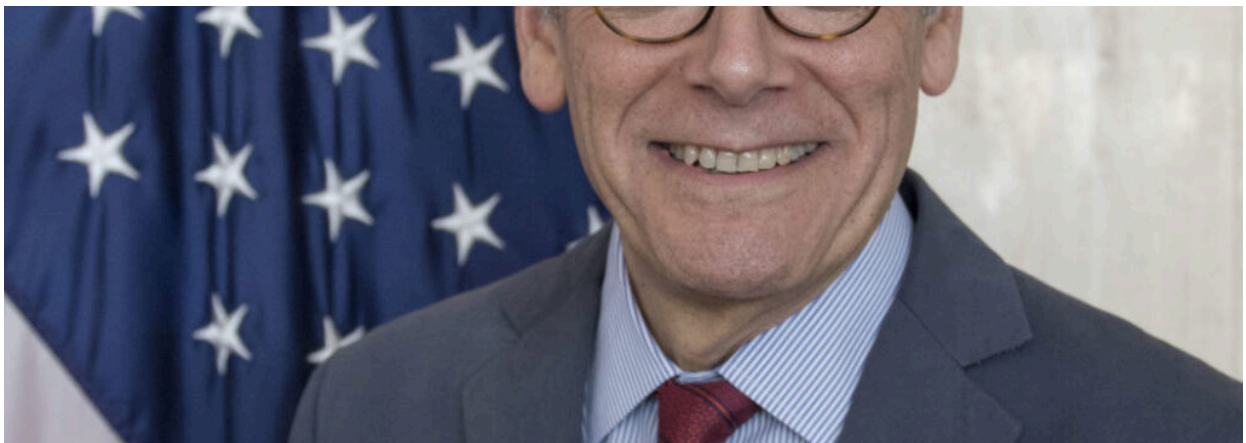
[Issues](#) ▼

[Analysis](#) ▼

[Events & Engagem](#)

[Our Experts](#) ▼

[Donate](#)



Amb. Jeffrey DeLaurentis

[Subscribe](#)

[Search](#)



[What We Do](#) ▼

[Issues](#) ▼

[Analysis](#) ▼

[Events & Engagem](#)

[Our Experts](#) ▼

[Donate](#)

[Ethics & Independence](#)

[Funding & Finances](#)

[Our Core Values](#)

[People](#)

[Staff & Affiliates](#)

[Board of Directors](#)

[Work at Stimson](#)

[Contact](#)

General

202.223.5956

1211 Connecticut Ave NW, 8th Floor, Washington, DC 20036

Fax: 202.238.9604

Media Inquiries

202.478.3437

Caiti Goodman,

Communications Dept.

[Subscribe](#)

[Search](#)

STIMSON

[What We Do](#) ▼

[Issues](#) ▼

[Analysis](#) ▼

[Events & Engagem](#)

[Our Experts](#) ▼

[Donate](#)